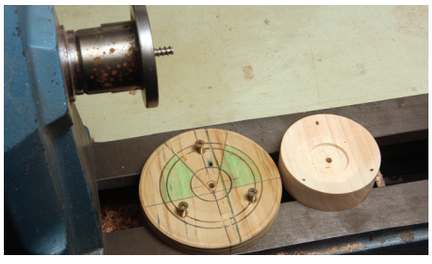
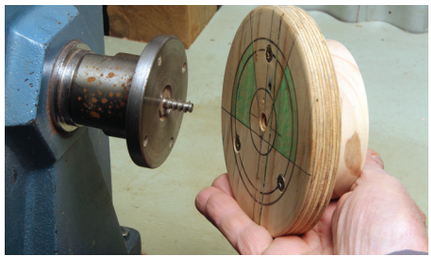
There is a particular problem with the knights: accurately and safely cutting the two men from each profiled ring. The solution involves preparing a special backing plate, and then sawing the finish-turned ring while screwed to that backing plate. **The operations to produce a knight were:**

1. Prepare one workpiece disc slightly oversize for the two knights for each side.
2. Drill a hole of the diameter appropriate for your screw chuck though each disc.
3. Mount the disc on your screw chuck. Skim the disc's right-hand face flat.
4. Remount the disc on the screw chuck with what was its right-hand face against the face of the screw chuck. Accurately finish-turn the disc's periphery to 100mm diameter and 32mm wide. Then finish-turn the disc's right-hand face, partially turn the 40mm hole and sand the finish-turned surfaces.
5. Repeat steps 3 and 4 for the second workpiece disc.
6. To prepare the backing plate saw out a disc of about 120mm diameter from 19mm or thicker wood or plywood – plywood is preferred. Drill a hole, typically 6mm, through the plate's centre so that the plate can be mounted on your screw chuck. Mount the backing plate on your screw chuck, true its periphery and pencil on circles of 40mm and 100mm diameter.
7. Remove the backing plate from the screw chuck. Finish marking out on what was the plate's right-hand face. Drill and countersink the backing plate for the three screw holes.
8. Screw the backing plate onto the screw chuck with its marked out face to the left. Check the outside diameter of the two knight workpieces. Turn a shallow annular recess into the right-hand face of the backing disc to neatly locate the finish-turned rim of the smaller-diameter workpiece – ideally, however, the diameter of both workpieces should be equal.
9. If necessary, remove the backing plate from the screw chuck, and screw the smaller-diameter knight workpiece with its grain in the correct orientation onto the backing plate. The three screws enable the two knights to be bandsawn free safely. The screws used should be short enough so that they won't damage the gouge's cutting edge as a workpiece's new right-hand face is finish turned.
10. Screw the backing plate and workpiece assemblage onto the screw chuck.
11. Finish-turn the right-hand face of the ring and complete the 40mm through hole. Sand.
12. Remove the backing plate and workpiece assembly.
13. Bandsaw along the marked lines on the backing plate. Only saw just past the 40mm diameter pencilled ring so that the backing plate can be used for the second workpiece.
14. If necessary, remount the backing plate on the screw chuck and slightly increase the diameter of the recess to suit the diameter of the rim of the finish-turned face of the second workpiece.
15. Repeat steps 9 to 13 for the second knight's workpiece.
16. Sand the sawn faces of the four knights by rubbing those faces on abrasive paper or cloth supported on a flat surface.
17. Hold each knight in a padded vice and drill the leading hole. I used a hand brace and a 12mm diameter auger.
18. Hand polish the knights.



Left to right: a commercial screw chuck, the backing plate and a white knight's ring after having its right-hand face and periphery finish-turned and sanded

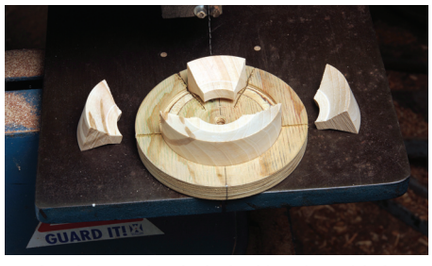


About to screw the backing plate and knight ring assemblage onto a commercial screw chuck. The knight ring-workpiece has been screwed to the backing plate using three screws. The screw's tips finish short of the finished surface

Turning the right-hand face of a knight's ring with a 12mm spindle detail gouge

Making the second bandsaw cut through the backing disc/knight ring assemblage

Making the last bandsaw cut to free the second knight



Bandsawing completed. The backing plate with the two waste ring sections still screwed to it, and the two freed white knights

Leading

Leading, here using lead shot and cross-linked PVA adhesive

To lead men you can melt sheet lead – obtainable from plumbing suppliers – in an old saucepan and pour it into the leading holes. Lead vapour is poisonous, so do this in a very well ventilated space. Also, unless the wood is fully seasoned, when you pour the lead into the hole, you'll likely get a Roman candle-like eruption of molten lead droplets. For my set I chose instead to make a mortar of epoxy or other suitable gap-filling glue and lead shot – obtainable from gunsmiths – which I pressed into the leading holes.

Conclusion

The cone is a set signature that offers many possibilities. As usual it's the knight which is the problem. Here I've substituted a triangular-profiled ring for the cone. ●

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